okay—they would say that he is appointed by BJP, so they will still vote for me. That is the commitment of our cadre on the entire coastal Karnataka.' Before the BJP, the Jan Sangh too had won its first-ever election victory of any kind in south India in coastal Karnataka when Dr V.S. Acharya was elected president of the Udupi City Municipality in 1968.[78] He later became home minister in the second Yediyurappa government in 2008.[79]

Until the late 1980s, the party was largely sustained by RSS pracharaks. Among them was Bhaurao Deshpande, originally from the RSS and later organising secretary of the Jan Sangh,[80] who is regarded as the party's chief builder in its early days in Karnataka.[81] Deshpande, after whom the BJP office in Bengaluru is named, is said to have also groomed Yediyurappa. Also from the RSS were pracharaks like Yadav Rao Joshi (1914–1992), a Nagpur Brahmin who initiated the Sangh's work in Karnataka in 1941.[82] He is regarded as a father figure by many RSS workers, who say he was also a 'good musician like Bhimsen Joshi'.[83]

The interesting question here is, why did the BJP not expand outwards from the coastal areas until the 1990s? The answer lies in the language barrier. The early pracharaks were all from Maharashtra and spoke Marathi, not Kannada. Radhakrishnan Holla, RSS communications head for Karnataka, told me that 'in the early days, in the 1960s and '70s, we were big in Bangalore and Mangalore and areas like Shivamogga. In those days, the pracharaks came from Maharashtra, so language was a huge problem.'[84] RSS worker Vadhiraj added that linguistic barriers did not matter in the coastal areas where 'the language was Konkani, so they could talk there in the old days'.[85] BJP MLC Lehar Singh explained that 'initially the party grew with north Indians from Bangalore, who were attracted to Jan Sangh'. He too had moved to the city in 1969 from Udaipur.[86] In the early 2000s, however, the RSS began training local pracharaks who spoke Kannada. This is borne out by the Karnataka Sangh's social-media pages, which by 2020 were predominantly in Kannada (see Chapter 12).[87]